Art, which helps us understand many other aspects of life, offered only limited assistance in this case. Poets, playwrights and moviemakers have occasionally focused on the dynamics of bureaucratic power. However, this has proven to be a very difficult story to communicate. Artists usually work with a limited set of story lines that are rooted in our biology, but none of these biological dramas sheds much light on the workings of bureaucracy, because they have all been scripted by evolution millions of years before the emergence of documents and archives. To understand what 'biological dramas' are, and why they are a poor guide for understanding bureaucracy, let's consider in detail the plot of one of humanity's greatest artistic masterpieces – the *Ramayana*.

One important plotline of the *Ramayana* concerns the relations between the eponymous prince, Rama, his father, King Dasharatha, and his stepmother, Queen Kaikeyi. Though Rama, being the eldest son, is the rightful heir to the kingdom, Kaikeyi persuades the king to banish Rama to the wilderness and bestow the succession instead on her son Bharata. Underlying this plotline are several biological dramas that go back hundreds of millions of years in mammalian and avian evolution.

All mammal and bird offspring depend on their parents in the first stage of life, seek parental care and fear parental neglect or hostility. Life and death hang in the balance. A cub or chick pushed out of the nest too soon is in danger of death from starvation or predation. Among humans, the fear of being neglected or abandoned by one's parents is a template not just for children's stories like *Snow White*, *Cinderella* and Harry Potter but also for some of our most influential national and religious myths. The *Ramayana* is far from being the sole example. In Christian theology damnation is conceived as losing all contact with the mother church and the heavenly father. Hell is a lost child crying for his or her missing parents.

A related biological drama, which is also familiar to human children, mammalian cubs and avian chicks, is 'Father loves me more than he loves you.' Biologists and geneticists have identified sibling rivalry as one of the key processes of evolution.[35] Siblings routinely compete for food and parental attention, and in some species the killing of one sibling by another is commonplace. About a quarter of spotted hyena cubs are killed by their siblings, who typically enjoy greater parental care as a result.[36] Among sand tiger sharks, females hold numerous embryos in their uterus. The first embryo that reaches about ten centimetres in length then eats all the